establishing Bhosle's prowess as a ghazal singer. When composing for *Umrao Jaan* (1981), Khayyam had a singular vision. "It was Asha or no one. To this day, I cannot imagine anyone else singing 'In ankhon ki masti' or 'Dil cheez kya hai'. She had heard my early ghazals like 'Sham-e-gham ki qasam', so she immediately understood what I was looking for," the composer told me in an interview. Only rarely, as with *Umrao Jaan*, did the courtesan play a pivotal role, but Bhosle's voice ensured that subaltern female characters were charged with a kind of atypical stardom that took on a life outside of their films. Actor Helen, upon whom several songs rendered by Bhosle were pictured, said after Bhosle's passing: "I am who I am because of her."

In the 1998 film *Saaz*, directed by Sai Paranjpye, Bansi, a character portrayed by Shabana Azmi and loosely based on Asha Bhosle, has a breakdown after she sings her first film song alongside her more famous older sister, Mansi, played by Aruna Irani. Mansi, of course, was meant to depict Lata Mangeshkar. Bansi is inconsolable and resentful because Mansi monopolises the song 'Baadal chaandi barsaaye', only allowing her to participate as a backup vocalist. A slighted Bansi tells her older sister: "*Agar tumhare sahaare rahi toh sada shuruwat hi rahegi meri. Hamesha rim jhim rim jhim hi gaati rahoongi* (If I depend on you, I will always remain at the starting point and forever be humming 'rim jhim rim jhim'). Unsurprisingly, both Lata and Asha distanced themselves from the film. However, it is evident from Bharatan's biography that Bhosle's need to make a space for herself compelled her to make the choices that she did while building her repertoire.





THE HIGH NOTES (Clockwise from above) Asha Bhosle receives the Padma Vibhushan from President Pratibha Patil in 2008; with Kishore Kumar and R.D. Burman in 1986; with British popstar Boy George at the Asha Bhosle Concert in London in 2000 and with elder sister Lata Mangeshkar

Bhosle's need to make a space for herself distinct from Lata's compelled her to make the choices she did while building her repertoire



ALAMY

AN INDIPOP STAR

The music video generation enabled Bhosle's ambition to soar higher. Bhosle's appearance in the video for 'Jaanam samjha karo', a Hindi pop track composed by Leslie Lewis in 1997, was the beginning of the singer's reinvention as an Indipop star. It was also in the mid-'90s that Bhosle was sought out by Rahman for the soundtrack of *Rangeela* (1995). The lusty open-throated vocals, once reserved for cabaret songs, were now recast for the film's main heroine as she celebrated life ('Rangeela Re') and wanted to find love ('Tanha Tanha'). In a video interview commemorating its 25th anniversary, Bhosle said, "It was tough to sing the title track as I was accustomed to singing with an orchestra. But here I was, singing along just to a rhythm and pitch track. Also, some parts were very high-pitched and I thought would be difficult, but I managed. When I went back to sing 'Tanha Tanha', Rahman asked me if I wanted to listen to 'Rangeela Re', and I was speechless when I heard it. I could hear strings, a drum section, and it all sounded perfect. I realised that I was working with an artist par excellence." Bhosle went on to sing for Rahman for the soundtracks of other films, including *Lagaan* (2001) and *Taal* (1999).

Bhosle's stardom also drew some of